

Authenticity, crossing, and appropriation

LING 103: Language and Society

What is cultural appropriation?

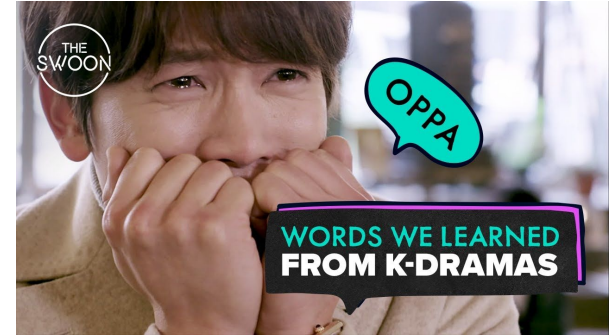
“...the act of taking or using things from **a culture that is not your own**, especially without showing that you understand or respect this culture...” -
Cambridge Dictionary

“...when members of **a majority group adopt cultural elements of a minority group in an exploitative, disrespectful, or stereotypical way**... appropriation involves a lack of understanding of or appreciation for the historical context that influences what is being taken...” -
Britannica



How does this extend to linguistic appropriation?

- use of language that is culturally specific:
 - African American Vernacular English (AAVE)
 - queer speech
 - non-English languages, e.g. Spanish, Korean
- **language can be “adopted” by outgroups**, which can be commodificational, can signal identities and social meaning, etc.
- what separates “authentic” or “appreciative” vs. “appropriative” use of language?



who, what, why, and how? (Fought 2006)

- **adolescents are most likely to partake in linguistic crossing**, especially beyond the use of slang, but of an entire linguistic code
- various functions of use of Creole in London youth:
 - resistance of adult dominance
 - challenge expectations of adolescents
 - signal of identity and alliance
 - general symbol of youth culture
- exposure to language as a result of **social networks and SES**, as well as **consumption of media** through film, hiphop, and other music

who, what, why, and how? (Fought 2006)

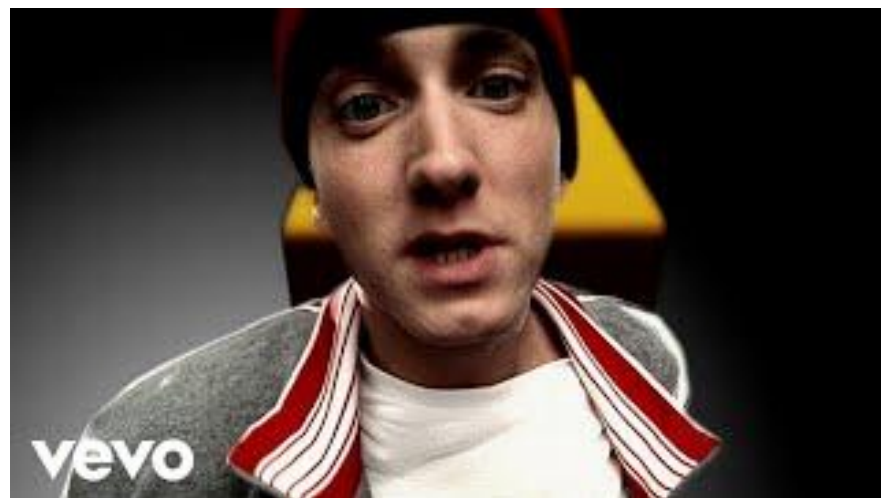
- boundaries in the **extent of crossing that is acceptable**:
 - slang vs. grammatical structures vs. phonology
- difference between **authentic vs. non-authentic use** of crossing:
 - the levels of exaggeration, correct usage, stereotyping, etc.
 - genuine exposure and interaction with native Creole speakers
 - context of use, e.g. with white vs. black peers
- **validation and “passing” depends on nuance** of crossing

- why is **more acceptable for slang to be adopted** into mainstream language and culture than other aspects of language?
- can it be appropriative for a member of a speech community to **“exaggerate” characteristics of their own language?**
- what does it mean when an individual is **given “permission” or “approval”** to cross into a language of a minoritized community?
- does the term “crossing” or “appropriation” assume **a division between definitive categories of language** and/or their speech communities?

performance of AAE by Iggy Azalea (Eberhardt & Freeman 2015)

- appropriation can be used **for profit**
- selective use and contrast of white and black culture to **strategically construct a persona**
- lack of cultural competence and respect for **historical and social context**
 - history of hip hop as a medium of political resistance and solidarity
 - employment of language to be subversive or invert expectations
- “...but I'm not **trying to sound black**—I just grew up in a country where on TV and in music and film, everyone was American or any Australian person in them **put on an American accent**... so I never saw it as strange at all...” - Iggy Azalea





performance of AAE by Iggy Azalea (Eberhardt & Freeman 2015)

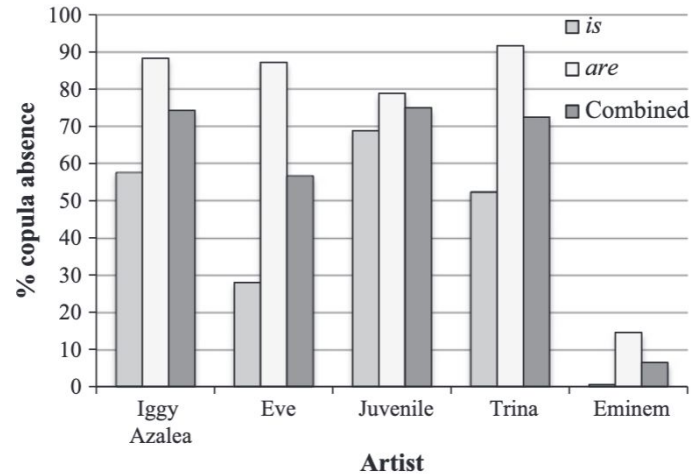


Figure 1: Comparison of copula absence among five artists' lyrics

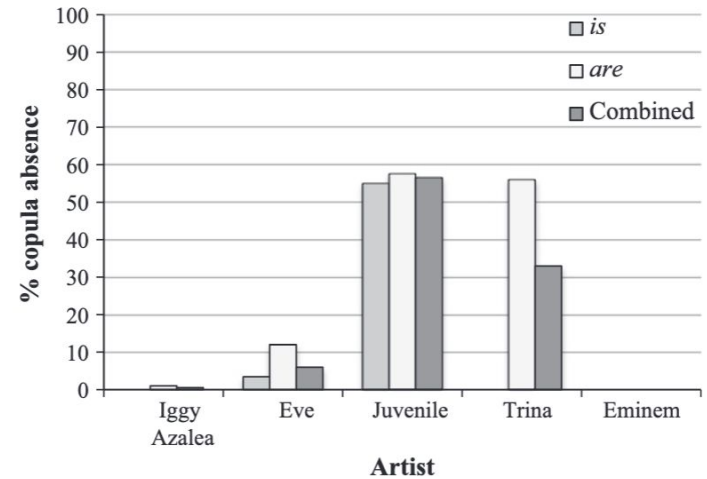


Figure 2: Comparison of copula absence among five artists' interview speech

- why is the cultural and/or linguistic persona constructed by Iggy Azalea and her music **deemed as appropriative and inauthentic?**
- is it problematic for white people who spend significant amounts of time with black communities to acquire “**native-like**” **use of AAE?**
- are issues of appropriation involving racially coded varieties of speech **different from other instances of acquiring types of speech?**
- does the appropriate use of language have different parameters when it comes to **everyday speech versus artistic or musical expression?**

What separates appropriation from assimilation or borrowing?

- appropriation is typically **defined within the social context** of a dominant group adopting the culture/language of a minoritized group
 - for purposes of commodification, selective access, etc.
 - outcome of exotification, ridicule, stereotyping, and misrepresentation
- assimilation is defined as a process where immigrants or minoritized groups come to resemble the dominant group in culture/language
 - for purposes of acceptance, social and economic advantage, etc.
- **are the linguistic mechanisms behind the use of language** in an appropriative versus assimilatory manner different? or is it just the **social context within which these processes occur?**

What separates appropriation from language learning?

- Eberhardt and Freeman discuss appropriation in terms of whether language use is **culturally accurate and grammatically correct**
- **language learning involves errors and approximation**, and L2 acquisition of an unfamiliar language is generally seen as unproblematic
 - includes the teaching and learning of a different language/culture
 - or “languages” of niche speech communities (e.g. academia, gaming, etc.)
- are **the linguistic mechanisms behind the use of language** in an appropriative versus language learning manner different? why do circumstances of appropriation require extra **sensitivity and caution**?

It's GIFing Gay: images on Gay Twitter (O'Neill 2023)

- reaction GIFs and images on multi-modal platforms in **relation to gender and sexuality**
- an **overrepresentation of feminine and/or black individuals** by non-black gay men
- four personas on British gay twitter:
 - the battle axe - female and white
 - the hun - female and white
 - the sassy queen - female and black
 - the flamboyant gay - male and queer





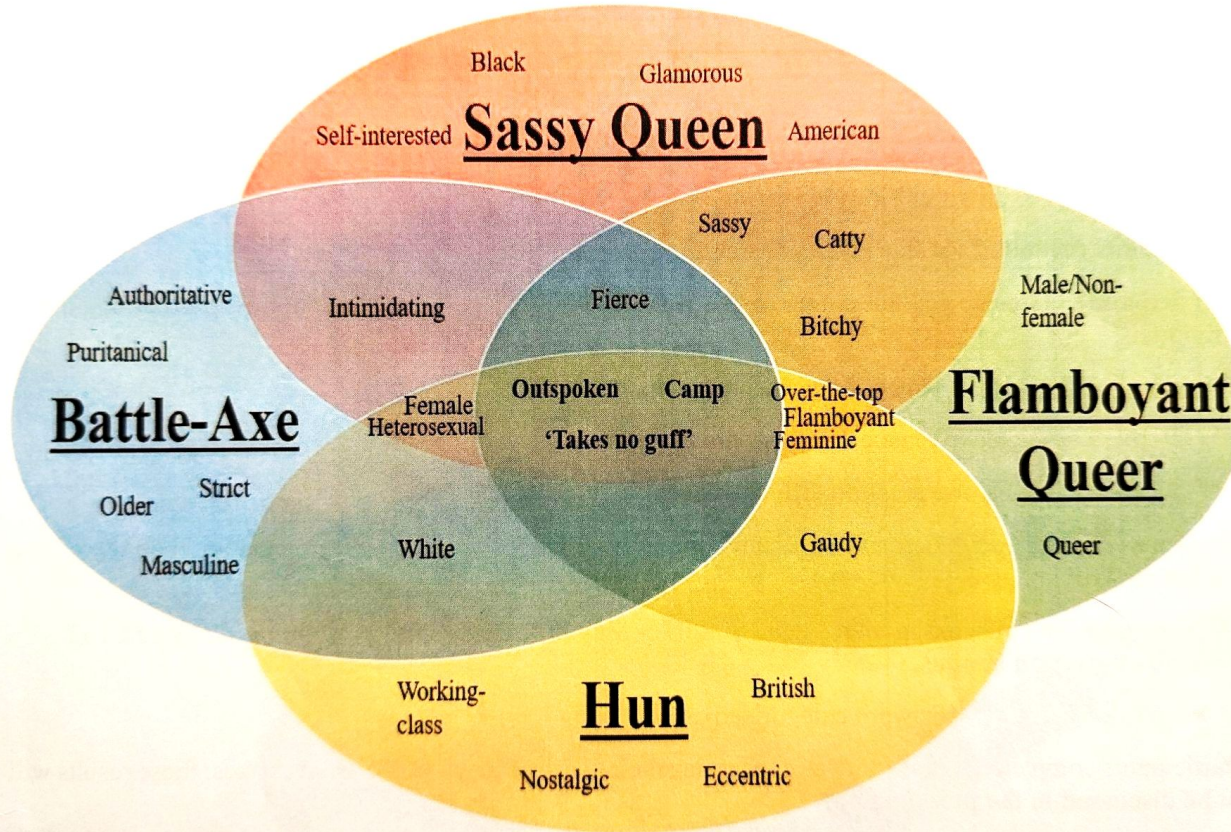
A Brief History of the Hun, the Most Relatable Woman in Britain

JULY 24, 2016

BLOODY DIFFICULT WOMEN – RECLAIMING THE BATTLEAXE



It's GIfing Gay: images on Gay Twitter (O'Neill 2023)



- what are **the motives of an individual** when they partake in linguistic or cultural appropriation? are these motives always bad?
- how do linguistic variables interact with their cultural origins, and **how do these variables evolve under the process of appropriation?**
- are individuals responsible for **knowing the historical context of language?** when does appropriated language become mainstream?
- what are the **consequences felt in minoritized communities** when their language is appropriated? can the outcomes be good or bad?